

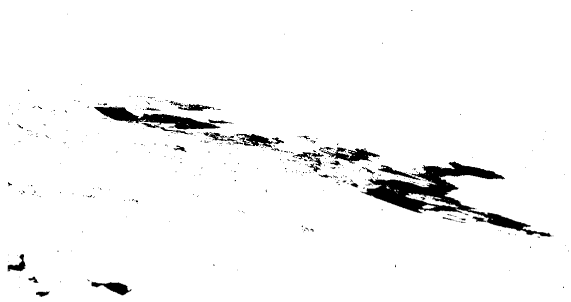
In the end it was the lust for these same sea otter skins that brought about the downfall of the Island Indians. The European invaders as well as the American ship captains brought in Indian hunters from Alaska and the coast of British Columbia. For many years the Aleut, Haida and Tlingit Indians pursued the "sea beavers" and in so doing came into conflict with the Channel Island tribesmen, to the ultimate wiping out of the surviving inhabitants of those deserts in the sea.

By the early 1800's only a few Indians were reported living on the islands of San Clemente and San Nicolas. Those on Santa Rosa, Santa Cruz and San Miguel, living closer to the mainland, had been gradually drifting thence to come under the aegis of the mission fathers.

THE LOST WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS

The accounts vary as to who was responsible for the destruction of the dwindling populace of San Nicolas. J. J. Warner, writing for the *Los Angeles Star*, December 13, 1856, said:

"In the prosecution of collecting furs along this coast by the Russian Fur Company, a large party of traders and hunters composed of Russians, half-breeds and Codiac Indians, were in 1818, hunting and trading at the Island of San Nicolas.



SAN NICOLAS ISLAND

This is the bleak shore looking north from Ranch House Landing, over which Juana Maria trudged, and is on the route followed by Nidever and his party in the search for the Lost Woman. (Photo by Art Woodward, July 1939)

"During their stay on the Island jealousies sprang up and with them difficulties and broils occurred between the hunters and the natives. The inhabitants were simple and harmless, their numbers insufficient to cause internal discord, and their remote situation offered no opportunity to cultivate the science of war. The hunters and traders were the reverse of harmlessness and simplicity and without difficulty or loss on their part exterminated all of the inhabitants which they could discover except a small number of females whom they carried away with them on their departure.

"Two men and two women were undiscovered in their hiding place and after the sailing of the hunting party remained the only inhabitants on the Island. Their numbers were increased by the slow but gradual course of nature until 1836, when the population consisted of seven persons, four male and three females, one of whom of about twenty years of age was of a fairer tint than her companions.

"The otter hunters from Santa Barbara and Los Angeles who from 1830 to 1836 in the prosecution of their business along the shore of the mainland and the neighboring Islands sometimes extended the scene of their operations to the more remote Island. The reports they gave of the timid half-breed maiden of San Nicolas occasioned considerable sensation among their fellow hunters who had not visited the Island, or who, on their visits had not been so fortunate as to discover the inhabitants who invariably sought to avoid the observation of strangers. Repeated attempts were made by hunters at various times to induce this solitary family to hold intercourse with them but which were only partially successful.

"In the summer of 1836, an American and an Englishman, residents of Los Angeles, set out for the purpose of bringing away this family. After much delay and difficulty in accomplishing this object they succeeded in getting six of the seven persons on board their vessel and sailed for San Pedro."

(In April, 1946 I was informed by Mr. Leo M. Harloe of Compton that his grandfather Capt. Marcus Harloe, a part Scot, part English sea captain then living in Los Angeles accompanied Isaac Williams on this expedition.) Continued Warner:

"They were brought to Los Angeles where from the change of diet and habits they soon sickened and died, with the exception of one old man and one middle-aged female. The former became blind in consequence of his sickness but instinctively found his way to the ocean's shore, where, recovering his health, he for many years was the most notable object that met the eye of the visitor or traveler at San Pedro. He was unfortunately drowned by falling from a steep bank into the ocean. The latter lived for many years in the family of one of the most respectable citizens in whose care she was at the time of her death. The solitary female that was left on the Island in consequence of her flight from those who brought away her relatives, remained there in regal solitude. She was frequently seen by the hunters who visited the Island in subsequent years, but all efforts to hold communication with here were unsuccessful, as she invariably fled from the approach of every human being.

"About 1853 or 1854 Mr. George Nidever, who for many years had been engaged in otter hunting and had frequently visited the Island, found her, old, infirm and decrepit, suffering from hunger and succeeded in removing her from her solitary and lonesome abode."

In another article by Warner, which appeared in the *Star* (n.d.) and was reprinted in the *Evening Bulletin*, San Francisco, December 27, 1856, the author stated that the American vessel commanded by Captain Whittmore, with about thirty Kodiak Indians on board, was at San Nicolas in 1811. It was at this time the difficulties arose between the islanders and the intruders. If such was the case it is quite probable the ship was the *Charon*, owned by P. T. Jackson of Boston, under command of Captain Isaac Whittmore. However, since his schedule does not place him at San Nicolas in that year, it may well be that Warner was mistaken in the name of the captain. Three other ships, the *Albatross* under Capt. Nathan Winship, the *Isabella*, William Heath Davis in command, and the

O'Cain under Jonathin Winship, Jr., all having Kodiak hunters on board, were in the Island waters taking otter during 1810-1811. One account states that the firm of Boardman & Pope was the owner of the offending ship. The *O'Cain* was owned by that company in Boston. Frankly I do not know who was responsible for the alleged slaying of most of the surviving Indians on San Nicolas. The fact remains that by 1825-1836 there was only a handful of San Nicoleño left on the dying island.

The mission fathers at Santa Barbara are generally credited with having sent the *Peor es Nada* out to remove the survivors from San Nicolas. Dr. Stephen W. Bowers, editor of the *Ventura Observer*, stated in his article, "The Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island," December 20, 1892, that the schooner, *Peor es Nada* (Nothing is Worse) or Nothing Can Be Worse) was owned in Monterey and had been chartered for the trip by Lewis F. Burton and Isaac J. Sparks for the trip to San Nicolas. He also said the captain was Charles Hubbard, and the majority of the crew were Kanakas (Polynesians); an American, known as Bill Williams also accompanied them, and they set sail with the blessing of Father Gonzales of Santa Barbara mission, about August 1, 1835. (The latter statement on the part of Bowers, is, I believe, somewhat erroneous since, at the time when the *Peor es Nada* sailed, Fr. Antonio Jimeno was in charge of Mission Santa Barbara. There was a Leandro Gonzalez at the mission at this time, but he was a hired field overseer, not the spiritual head of the establishment. If any priest dispatched the vessel it may have been Fray Jimeno. Fr. José María Gonzalez, who arrived on the coast in January 1833, did not take any post at Santa Barbara until the spring of 1842, seven years after the Indians had been removed from San Nicolas.)

At any rate the small vessel arrived off the north shore of the Island, presumably about the 3rd or 4th of August, 1835, and a party went ashore to round up the Indians. Apparently the natives were glad to be taken off. There is no harbor worthy of the name on San Nicolas. The waters about the place are treacherous. Ground swells are heavy, and at times the surf pounds the sweeping crescents of sandy beaches on both sides with tremendous force and high waves, making landing in small boats almost impossible. There is one very tiny enclosed harbor known today as Corral Harbor, just north of the old Ranch House Landing (the latter being about midway on the north shore) where small row boats can put in, or at least could before the tiny refuge sanded in. Entrance to Corral Harbor was through a narrow passage in the rocks, and it was just about wide enough for a small skiff. Here in times past the Indians, no doubt, guided their plank canoes to a safe landing. Here too was a small spring, welling out of the ledges—good, sweet water; the last potable spring before Ranch House Landing beach was reached.

It may well be that the *Peor es Nada* beat up and down the island offshore while the ship's boat went into Corral Harbor. The water beyond the breakers was too deep to afford good anchorage, and in certain seasons of the year, squalls rise suddenly, making it

imperative for larger craft to stand out to sea to avoid being swept ashore. Stories vary as to how the "lost woman" came to be left on shore.

One version has it that when the Indians were assembled at the landing place, a young woman, about twenty-five years of age, suddenly broke away from the group and started back west along the north shore. The other tribesmen said she had left her young baby asleep in one of the huts, and in the excitement of embarking preparations, had forgotten the youngster.

The other story is that all of the Indians were safely on board the vessel when the woman, uttering a scream of anguish, plunged overboard and swam back to shore to get her child. The captain of the schooner fearing the stormy warnings of a dropping glass, stood out to sea and cruised up and down as long as he dared. The storm increased, and the huge breakers pounding the beach precluded any attempts to launch the ship's boat. So the *Peor es Nada* sailed away from San Nicolas to take refuge in the lee of Santa Barbara Island, and thence proceeded to San Pedro, where she disembarked the refugees. *Manana* they would return for the lone woman and her child. But, in California as in all Latin controlled countries, *manana*, is truly the tomorrow that never comes. Days merged into weeks; weeks became months; months turned into years; shipping became scarce along the coast. The *Peor es Nada* was sunk. Gradually the memory of the abandoned Indian mother and her baby became a sort of a folk tale, which remained alive only in the minds of the inhabitants of the sleepy little villages of Santa Barbara and Los Angeles. Yes, someday someone would go out and rescue her. But as the years drifted by, no one ever did.

By the time of the gold rush the story of how this female Robinson Crusoe came to be left on the island was quite vague.

Mrs. John McDougall, a passenger on board the steamship *California*, bound north from Panama to San Francisco made this entry in her journal for Thursday, May 3, 1849:

"In coming to Santa Barbara we passed an island about sixty miles from the coast, on which there is a lone woman living. The Russians some years ago, had a party there catching otter; a storm coming up they were obliged to put out to sea, leaving some of their party on shore. They afterwards returned and got them all off but this woman, who has lived there alone ever since. Some years ago they caught her but she was perfectly wild and had lost her speech, so they left her."

No doubt other stories in circulation at the time were just as vague and off beat as this one. Luckily we do have more correct versions of the final chapter in the life drama of this last inhabitant of San Nicolas. Two of the men who were in the search party that found the woman have left us their stories of what happened.

George Nidever, an ex-mountain man, and Carl Dittman, *alias* Charles Brown, a native of Prussia, were the men who eventually tracked the all but forgotten islander to her isolated hut of whalebone and brush standing on the bleak, windswept ridge comprising the west end of the Island.

During the remainder of his lifetime Nidever gave a number of interviews in which he related the particulars of his finding of the "lost woman." And, after her removal to the mainland at Santa Barbara, she was baptized "sub condicionem" by Fr. Francisco Sanchez as Juana María, by which name she has been known to history ever since.

Perhaps the best account ever published concerning the discovery and bringing back to civilization of Juana María was that written by Emma Chamberlain Hardacre of Santa Barbara. It appeared under the title "Eighteen Years Alone" in *Scribner's Monthly*, September 1880. It was reprinted in pamphlet form in 1950 by her niece, Miss Elizabeth Mason. There are discrepancies in her account, as indeed there are in all such yarns. Nidever added to or left out details in his various versions and I shall not attempt any lengthy comparison of these accounts in this brief resume of the incident.

George Nidever was born December 20, 1802, in eastern Tennessee. In May 1830 he was one of a group of trappers that left Fort Smith, Arkansas, headed for the Rocky Mountains. In 1833 the young hunter was a member of Joseph Reddeford Walker's party when it came into California. Nidever remained in California, eventually settling in Santa Barbara. He continued to hunt, however, and had many adventures on the water and ashore. He went to the diggings in the spring of 1848, but the deaths of so many companions by fever drove him out. In 1849 he again returned to try his luck, but his luck didn't hold out. He bought a small schooner of 17 tons burden in San Francisco in January 1850. In this he returned to Santa Barbara, where he had decided to settle. In the year 1851 Nidever went on several short otter hunts. Shortly after purchasing the vessel he bought out the interests of a man by the name of Bruce, who had a sheep ranch on San Miguel Island, and stocked the island with sheep, cattle, hogs and horses. This ranch he maintained for seventeen years. In those days the titles to the islands of San Miguel, Santa Cruz and San Nicolas were clouded, to say the least. Men bought and sold the rights to occupy them without having the least vestige of a title to the lands. They built ranch houses and made other improvements in spite of the fact that the islands, with the exception of Santa Rosa, Santa Catalina and Santa Cruz, were all the possessions of the United States government. However, such little matters as lack of title did not deter these pioneers from claiming the islands as their own. In 1870 Nidever "sold" the island to the Mills brothers for \$10,000.

In April 1852 Nidever sailed out to San Nicolas Island with Tom Jeffries, and a crew of two Indians. At that time sea gull eggs were in great demand, and since there were many gulls on San Nicolas they anticipated a good harvest. It was on this trip that Nidever saw the first evidences that the lone woman of San Nicolas was still alive. Let him tell the story in his own words, as he dictated it to E. F. Murray September 1, 1878, and published and annotated by William Henry Ellison in *The Life and Adventures of George Nidever*, University of California Press, 1937:

"We went direct to San Nicolas and having arrived early in the day, Jeffries, one of the Indians, and I landed and travelled along the beach towards the upper end of the Island some 6 or 7 miles. At a short distance from the beach, about 200 yards, we discovered the foot prints of a human being, probably that of a woman as they were quite small. They had evidently been made during the previous rainy season as they were well defined and sunk quite deep into the soil then soft, but now dry and hard." (p77)

The party also found the weather-beaten remains of three small circular brush enclosures about six feet in diameter, with walls standing about five feet, grass growing inside them and giving no evidences of having been occupied for some time. Apparently these were the temporary shelters built by Juana María, which she used from time to time when absent from her more permanent resident on the west end of the island. On poles ranging from four to eight feet in length, which were thrust into the ground around these jacales, were pieces of sun dried seal blubber which the men estimated had been there about three or four months. These windbreaks were located about two miles apart, and stood on slight elevations back from the beach, perhaps two or three hundred yards. On this expedition Nidever states he landed on the south side of the island. I presume the schooner may have been lying off the stretch of beach we know as Dutch Harbor, which is a harbor in name only, and is probably the only semi-decent anchorage on that side of the island. (We camped at this place November-December 1940, excavating a small, open, badly eroded village site on a slight elevation back a few hundred feet from the beach. From this place we took quantities of sea-grass cordage, coarse matting, fragments of short sea-grass frontal skirts and basketry. It may well have been one of the places where Juana María had one of her temporary camps, but I believe the material we excavated from the shell heap antedated her lonely vigil.)

When the schooner's anchor began dragging, Nidever improvised one by filling a large sack with stones. The gale which sprang up blew for eight days, at the end of which they left their uncertain position and ran over to Santa Barbara Island. The egg hunting had not panned out so well on San Nicolas as they had anticipated, and they had no better luck on the rocky islet of Santa Barbara, so they headed for home, minus their eggs but satisfied the "lost woman of San Nicolas" was still alive.

The news of the discovery of the evidence of Juana María spread throughout Santa Barbara. Father José María Gonzalez, who by this time *was* in charge of Mission Santa Barbara, heard of it. When Nidever decided to outfit for another trip to San Nicolas the following winter (1852), this time to take sea otter which apparently had staged a comeback in the waters around the island, Father Gonzales urged Nidever to make every effort to find the woman. On this trip Nidever was accompanied by Carl Dittman, or as he was then called, Charley Brown.

Again they landed on the south side of the Island, and headed toward the west end. At the head of the island Nidever sat down to rest while Dittman forged ahead. He rounded the end of the long sandy ridge, which terminates in a very rocky point at the



REGGIE LAMBERT AT CHARLES PETERSON'S GRAVE

The lone grave of this fisherman on San Nicolas is in the sand dunes above Corral Harbor. All traces of the grave had disappeared by 1940.

(Photo by Art Woodward, July 1939)



DYING SAN NICOLAS

View taken almost opposite opening of Corral Harbor, showing desolate sand dune area on northwest shore.

(Photo by Art Woodward from Fish and Game Patrol boat *Bluefin*, July, 1939)

extreme west end, and started down the north side, headed east. Here on the sandy beach he saw fresh footprints, but he lost them in the heavy carpeting of ground cover. He also found a small piece of drift wood which Juana María had evidently lost from her bundle as she made her way inland. It was on this trip that the party had first sighted some seven or eight wild dogs, about the size of a coyote, but they were black and white in color. Nidever thought that perhaps the animals had killed and eaten the woman, since they had seen no further signs of her. But discovery of the footprints, as well as the finding of a basket tucked away in the crotch of a high malva bush, convinced them she was indeed still alive. The basket was covered with a piece of seal-skin, and in the container were several shag-skins, nearly trimmed into squares, along with some bone needles and a long, tightly twisted sinew rope. Nidever started to replace the basket in the bush, then changed his mind, and scattered the contents upon the ground. He left the basket beside them—explaining that if on their next visit they came to this place and found the items replaced, they would know she was alive. They then returned to the schooner. Next day they searched again, but did not find her. Then they began hunting otter, which were very thick. After hunting three or four days, a strong southeaster came up, and continued for about a week. Rough water made hunting impossible, so once more they left San Nicolas. This time they ran over to San Miguel, where they took refuge in a good harbor (presumably Cuyler's Harbor) and laid by until the gale blew itself out. Afterwards they returned to Santa Barbara.

It was not until the summer of 1853 Nidever made his third attempt to find the stranded Indian woman. This time he was successful. With him went Charley Brown, a hunter; a red-faced Irishman, called "Colorado" because of his florid complexion; and four Mission Indians.

This time they landed about mid-way of the island, on the north side, or approximately where Ranch House Landing is located. They were equipped to remain for two or three months, and wanted not only to find the lost woman, but to take sea otter as well.

The first day they made tentative explorations along the shore toward the west end and, when within about one-half mile of the extreme western tip of the island, they found fresh footprints in the damp soil around a spring of water. This spring is, or was known in the 1930's, as Old Garden Spring, to distinguish it from the largest spring on the island, which is a mile or so east of New Garden Spring. Names of places on the island are never constant. Over the years they have changed according to the fancy or the lack of knowledge of the namer.

This day they didn't find the woman, but the fresh signs were encouraging. Early next morning all hands, except the Indian cook, went ashore and headed west toward the head of the island; four men striking across to the spot where the basket had been found in the malva bush on the previous trip. Nidever and Dittman (Brown) kept on toward

the western tip of land, skirting the north shore. Later the four men reported they found the basket with its contents carefully replaced in the bush.

Tramping the sands of San Nicolas is a tiring business. I know, because I have trudged every foot of beach on the place, as well as having crossed and recrossed the plateau on top of the island. No wonder then that Nidever got tired. He sat down to rest while Charley went on ahead.

In those days the surface of the terrain was not as barren as it now is. Low brush and grass covered the western hills, which are at present windswept, sandy ridges, where the sun reflects glaringly on bright days and over which the sea gulls mew in lonely flight against a backdrop of sullen gray clouds during squally weather.

Charley plodded on until he reached the very tip of the island, then he turned south and began climbing the long slope. The ridge is broken by a succession of two or three rounded terraces. En route to the summit he passed the brush-covered, whale-rib framework of several jacales, long since abandoned, with grass growing high within the open, deserted huts. (Brown's statements concerning tall grass growing on the dunes at that end of the island seem almost incredible today because those areas are now bare and as devoid of covering as a Chihuahua dog.)

Pausing to catch his breath Brown looked about him in all directions. Ahead of him, on what was approximately the highest point of the ridge, Charley saw only . . . "a small black object about the size of a crow, which seemed to be in motion." Said Brown: "What is that? It looks like a crow sitting on a whale bone." He continued toward the object:

"So when I came to find out it was her I took my gun and stuck my hat on and held it up to make signs to the Indians. I did not know if she would bite or scratch. I motioned the Indians to come along. She had a brush fence about two feet high to break the wind and right in front she sat facing me. The sun was coming in her face. She was skinning a seal before I came up to her."

Nidever relating the episode said:

"Looking about in all directions from this point he (Brown) discovered at a distance, along the ridge, a small black object about the size of a crow which appeared to be in motion. Advancing cautiously towards it, he soon discovered it to be the Indian woman, her head and shoulders only, visible above one of the small enclosures resembling those we had before discovered. He approached as near as he dared and then, raising his hat on his ramrod, signalled to the men who were then recrossing the low sandy stretch and were plainly visible from this point.

"They saw the signals and came toward him. In the meantime, the old woman was busily employed in stripping the blubber from a piece of seal skin which she held across one knee, using in the operation a rude knife made from a piece of iron hoop stuck into a piece of rough wood for a handle. She kept up a continual jabbering to herself and every few moments would stop and look in the direction of our men, whom she had evidently been watching, her hand placed over her eyes to shade them from the sun.

"Upon his first approach there were some dogs near which began to growl. These the old woman sent away with a yell but without looking in the direction of Charley. The men having come up, they quietly surrounded her to prevent any escape."

The long search was at last ended. Here before them sat the almost legendary "lost woman." She showed no fear as the men approached. Instead she bobbed her head and

smiled ingratiatingly, chattering away in her unintelligible island tongue. Not one of the Mission Indians could understand her. The men now signalled to Nidever to climb the slope, but he was tired. He couldn't see what they had found and didn't much care. His feet were tired, and whatever it was could wait until they returned. But the signals from the men now seated around Juana María became more insistent. Reluctantly he made his way to the top of the hill. When he arrived, the woman bowed and smiled at him. Apparently she was quite happy and, remembering her duties as an Indian hostess, she busied herself around the fire which was burning in the center of the enclosure. In the embers she placed some roots of two different kinds . . . "one called *carcomites* and the name of the other I do not know . . . As soon as they were roasted she invited us all to eat some."

The site of her hut was ideal for keeping watch over the west end of the island. Nidever describes it thus:

"The inclosure or hut where we found her was on the N.W. side and near the top of the ridge that forms the upper end of the Island. It was not far from the best springs of water, near to the best point for fish and seal, and it commanded a good view of the greater portion of the Island."

At this point I am going to break in upon Nidever's narrative and relate my own experiences in the re-discovery of the hut site once occupied by Juana María. On July 25, 1939, in company with Reggie Lamberth, who had come to San Nicolas the previous year with his wife and two children to work sheep for Roy Agee, lessee of the island, I set out on horseback to ride to the west end of San Nicolas. Our expedition, sponsored by the Los Angeles Museum with another of our fellow Westerners, Ex-Sheriff Don Meadows as leader of the biological division, had landed on San Nicolas on July 22, and since I was anxious to get busy on the archeological reconnaissance of the island, I gladly accepted Lamberth's offer of a horse. With his generous services as guide, we started out from our camp near the ranch house, headed west along the beach, covering practically the same route taken by Nidever and his companions eighty-six years earlier.

In my knapsack I had a copy of Ellison's *The Life and Adventures of George Nidever*, published in 1937. It proved a valuable guide to the landmarks we visited. We passed Corral Harbor, near which is a spring of sweet water, thence to New Garden Spring, from which a pipe line about two and a half miles long conducted drinking water to the ranch house. This entire area is covered with the remains of ancient camp-sites, where the Indians of Ghalas-at made their homes. Beyond New Garden Springs is another spring. Juana María used all of the sources of water mentioned. At last we came to the end of the island, just as Charley Brown had done. In my journal I noted:

"The point of the island is one long sand dune. Here in this ridge was the site of Juana María's hut. I photographed the site (ridge) from the east. We ate lunch at the Old Garden where the spring issues from a shelving rock just at the edge of tide line. This is Honeymoon Beach. It is a sandy beach in summer but in winter it is covered with drift wood. Abalone by the thousands cluster along this section of shore line on the rocky reefs.

JUANA MARÍA

"Today it dawned sunny, but the fog rolled in, and the sun came through only in intervals. In winter the gales lash the northwest end and heavy seas pound the beaches, tossing the spray inland."

We passed remnants of old whale-bone hut structures, which I duly noted. As we rode up the hill I remarked to Lamberth: "If Nidever was correct, then we should find the remains of Juana María's house on that high point." When we reached the spot I had indicated, there on the windswept summit were some nineteen pieces of whale-bone, pieces of ribs and scapulae which were scattered on the ground in a rough circle. Since it was the only evidence of any shelter on the site which corresponded to Nidever's description, it seemed logical that there could be only one answer, this was the wreck of the whale-bone and brush shelter once occupied by the lost woman of San Nicolas.

In other respects too, the site occupied by the hut corresponded to the description of the men who found it in 1853. Southwest of it, within plain sight is an enormous sea lion rookery and the incessant guttural barking of the animals came to us between blasts of wind. From that rookery Juana María obtained some of her sustenance. There too were the places where the sea gulls and shag nested, and west and southeast of us were the rocky reefs teeming with shell-fish and other sea life. Also plainly visible was the stretch of beach where Old Garden Spring was located, and further east along the coast were the



RANCH HOUSE LANDING BEACH

View from cliffs above the ranch house looking northeast toward beach. (Photo by Art Woodward, July, 1939)

other springs mentioned by Nidever, where Juana María had kept her supplies of dried meat tucked into crevices in the rocks and staked out on driftwood poles. From all of these sources of water she carried the life-giving fluid back to her campsites in the pitched grass water bottles which she wove endlessly.

Later, on a second trip to the island December 1, 1940, we again visited this place, and photographed the jacal site on top of the ridge. Then we re-erected the fallen pieces of whale bone, and a member of the party, a girl archeological assistant who was short in stature and possessed of a shock of wiry black hair, sat down in the center of the enclosure and we photographed her. In the picture all that can be seen of the girl was her black hair appearing over the top of the whale bone, just as described by Brown and Nidever. In 1949, I again visited the ridge, and found that the heavy whale-bones had again been blown flat by the blasts of the northeast gales. There we left them to gradually weather away and become part of the debris carried by wind and sand over the west end of the island.

But to revert once more to Nidever and the lost woman in 1853.

The sea otter hunters urged the woman to go with them. She was not unwilling. Said Brown:

"Old Man Nidever (he was then forty-one years of age. A.W.) said to the Indians, in case she would not come could not we take her by force. I said no, she is not afraid. So I took her by the shoulder and said *Vamoose* and she understood at once. I took everything she had and she took a big seal head in a basket and that was all. We all had something to carry. Then she had a little brand of fire and she took that away and wobbled along with a strange kind of step."

Nidever adds to the picture with more detailed observations:

"Just outside the inclosure or windbreak, as I should call it, was a large pile of ashes and another of bones, showing that this had been her abode for a long time. Nearby were several stakes with blubber on them, as we had seen around the others (inclosures). There was blubber also hanging on a sinew rope, similar to the one already described (The one found in the basket. A.W.) which was stretched between two stakes. Near the inclosure were several baskets, some in the process of construction also two bottle-shaped vessels for holding water; these as well as the baskets being woven, were of some species of grass very common on the Island. (The grass in question was the sea grass already mentioned. A.W.). There were also several other articles such as fishhooks made of bone and needles of the same material, lines or cords of sinews for fishing and the larger rope of sinews she no doubt used for snaring seals on the rocks where they came to sleep. . .

"The old woman was of medium height, but rather thick. She must have been about 50 yrs. old, but she was still strong and active. Her face was pleasing as she was continually smiling. Her teeth were entire but worn to the fums, the effect, no doubt, of eating the dried seal blubber. (Nidever was only partially correct in the latter diagnosis. Much of the attrition of the teeth of the California Indians came from the pulverized stone dust from the mortars in which the tribesmen pounded their seeds and dried meat and shell fish which mingled with their foodstuffs. A.W.)

"Her head, which had evidently been for years without any protection, was covered with thick matted hair, that was once black, no doubt, but now it had become a dull brown color. (Who was it that once remarked that except for a certain pigmentation of the hair all Chinamen would be red headed? A.W.)

"Her clothing consisted of but a single garment of the skins of shags made in the form of a gown. It fitted close at the neck, had no sleeves, was girded at the waist with a sinew cord, and reached nearly to the feet. She had another dress of the same material and make in one of the baskets. These were sewed with sinews, the needles used being of bone. This place was undoubtedly where she usually

lived, but in the rainy season she lived in a cave nearby." (Various references have been made to this cave on San Nicolas, but unfortunately our party in 1939-1940 never located it. I suspect it was either in the rough narrow canyons on the south side of the island or possibly in the "Roughs" on the east end. I regret very much never having seen this shelter. A.W.).

When it came to leaving her home Nidever corroborates Brown's statement, but added:

"She at once began putting her things into her baskets. Her basket filled she put it on her back and followed the Indians toward the beach, while we walked behind; each of us carrying some of her things. Seal meat, some of it stinking, and a seal's head from which putrefied brains were running, was all carefully put into the basket. (And, my friends, nothing stinks worse than a rotting seal carcass. A.W.). We soon arrived at a spring of water where we stopped and on some stakes which we found standing near we hung the things we were carrying, fixing them on the stakes in such a manner as to lead her to believe we took very great care of them. (This was Old Garden Spring, the nearest source of water to Juana Maria's hut site and the last potable water along the northwest side of the island. A.W.).

Leaving this place the men proceeded to the beach "where a spring issues from a shelving rock, just below the bank." This was the largest spring on San Nicolas, New Garden Spring. It comes out of the rock formation at the base of a steep bank. Here Juana Maria stopped to bathe and said Nidever:

"The men having gone on ahead, Charley and I remained on the bank above. This being finished, we proceeded to the boat and went on board the schooner. When we put her into the boat, she crept forward to the bow where she knelt, holding firmly on to either side of the boat. As soon as we got on board, she crept along side of the stove which was on deck."

Once Juana Maria was safely in their custody, Nidever and his men went about their job of hunting sea otter. The woman was perfectly content among her new friends. She worked around the camp, brought in wood, and continued her never-ending task of weaving and tarring baskets. Nidever remarked that he never saw her complete one of them. She enjoyed the pork and hard tack as a change in her diet and she was particularly fond of sugar or anything sweet. She smacked her lips after eating sugar to indicate her appreciation of it. However, she could never quite shake off the eternal spectre of hunger that had hovered over her in her lonely days. She saved every scrap of leftover food from the camp, even the bones, which she took out from time to time and sucked upon vigorously. One day Brown shot a she otter offshore and it was brought to land to be skinned. The carcass was hauled away to the water but Juana Maria protested angrily that this was a waste of good food. To humor her they left the animal's body nearby, but after it became too high even she did not argue the matter, when they finally threw it into the water.

(I wonder if this protestation was not more in the nature of a religious fear than a feeling of need for the flesh. Many tribesmen believed that the bones of water mammals should not be thrown into the rivers, lakes or sea because the spirits of the deceased animals would inform the live creatures that the human hunters didn't know how to treat their game. In Big Dog Cave on San Clemente we found a huge windrow of sea mammal and fish bones stacked up. It would have been so easy to pitch these bones into the ocean fourteen or fifteen feet below the mouth of the cave, but instead the thousands of bones were kept, long after the flesh had been removed.)

Finally the day came when Juana María was to leave her island home for the last time. The men, thinking that her shag skin garment was insufficient for her appearance in the pueblo of Santa Barbara, made a petticoat of mattress ticking. Charley Brown started the skirt but she indicated by signs that she could do it better, so he threaded a needle and let her go to work. A man's cotton shirt and a black necktie completed her ensemble. Nidever gave her an old cloak or cape, badly worn, but by dint of much hard work she made this into a serviceable covering.

En route to the mainland the schooner ran into a severe storm and when the gale increased Juana María intimated by signs that she had the power to quiet the wind. She knelt and prayed, facing into the wind and continued her chanting until at last the storm passed. Then she smiled and gave them to understand that it was only through her medicine that this had come about.

The vessel had to put into Santa Cruz until the storm was over, then it proceeded to Santa Barbara.

As the schooner approached the mainland Juana María became quite excited. She clapped her hands and danced gleefully on the deck. An ox-cart, plodding along the shore, was a strange and novel sight to her, and she exclaimed delightedly and pointed the wonderful phenomenon out to the men. When they landed she went immediately to the ox-cart, talking all the while as she examined every part of it. Dr. J. B. Shaw, an English physician, rode down to the beach on horseback, and this new marvel caused another outburst of excitement from Juana María, who signed to Nidever her impression of the horseman by placing her two fingers of her right hand astride the index finger of her left and imitating the motion of the horse.

News of the arrival of the sea otter hunters with their strange cargo was soon noised about Santa Barbara, and scarcely had Nidever reached his house with the woman when half the town was down to see her.

Juana María was the news sensation of the day. Word of her presence spread up and down the coast. She settled down at Nidever's, and received the townspeople by the score. And for several weeks she was the center of attraction, along with her shag-skin garments, her baskets, needles, etc. Mrs. Nidever took good care of Juana María. The island woman delighted in visiting the pueblo, and would wander from house to house, singing and dancing when requested. She seemed particularly fond of the children, thinking perhaps of her own lost youngsters. Many of the gifts she received were given to visiting children.

By signs, she made Charley Brown understand that at one time she had two children; at the time the first vessel called at San Nicolas to take the Indians off in 1835. One was probably a couple of years old. Said Brown, when queried about the fate of the infant which she had left asleep at the time:

"I understand she made signs so plain—she showed two fingers for two children and she

shook her breast; one was sucking and the other had teeth. She sucked her fingers."

Although various Indians were brought to see and talk with Juana María, not one could understand her.

Nidever, when queried by a Mr. J. Terry about 1882 concerning the fate of the sucking infant, said that one of the Indian women brought to see Juana María had learned through sign language that the San Nicoleño believed the dogs had killed and eaten it. There were many dogs running wild on the island at that time. By signs also she made her questioners understand that at the time of embarkation, the eldest child had probably been taken on board the *Peor es Nada*, and that as the vessel sailed away leaving her on the beach they had shouted "*manana*" at her, indicating they would return the next day . . . but they never came back.

Also Brown said that the dress brought ashore from Juana María's hut was given by Mrs. Nidever to the priests at the mission, who in turn sent it to Rome. Said Brown:

"She had bone needles with eyes drilled in and she had a knife made with bone, and another with a piece of wood that she had when I caught her cleaning the sealskin. She had nails pointed for catching fish with. She had the rope nicely twisted with sinews and had it twisted as true as any rope-maker could make, and she had bottles made of grass about the size of a gallon demijohn. We found some dishes of wood with handles."

Juana María's life ashore was all too short. Although she entered into the activities of her new world with a child-like zest, civilization was too much for her. Her new clothes were her prized possessions. Everyone was her friend. In vain did the priests attempt to piece together the history of her island life. Indians from Ventura, Santa Barbara and Santa Inez visited her and tried to understand her dialect, but with no results. She acquired a few words of Spanish. In her own tongue (presumably) man was *nache*, the sky *tegua*, and a hide or pelt was *toco*. She called Nidever *tata* or sometimes *nana*. (These are colloquial terms of endearment meaning "daddy" and "grandma" respectively.)

She was very fond of the new foodstuffs given her at Nidevers—especially green corn, vegetables and fresh fruits. When first brought ashore she was in excellent health, but her excessive use of the strange foods brought on attacks of dysentery. One day she fell from the Nidever porch, injuring her spine and probably causing internal injuries as well. Mrs. Nidever nursed her as best she could, but Juana María grew weaker and weaker. Thinking to tempt her failing appetite, a seal was killed and roasted and some of the meat brought to her. Even this did not rouse her. She laughed feebly and rubbed her fingers across her badly worn teeth, making signs that now she was too old, and her teeth too dull, to eat seal. She lingered four weeks, then died. She had only been in Santa Barbara seven weeks from the time she had been brought ashore from San Nicolas to the day of her death.

A captain of a coastwise steamer had offered Nidever \$1000 if he would permit the captain to take her on board and exhibit her up and down the coast as a side-show

curiosity. When asked why he did not do it, Nidever answered that he thought it didn't look right to sell a person. It may be that Captain C. J. W. Russell, a friend of Nidever and owner of a coastal steamer, was the man who made the offer. After Juana Maria's death, which occurred Tuesday, October 18, 1853, Nidever gave to Captain Russell a pitched water bottle, a stone mortar and some stone beads which had been among the possessions of the unfortunate woman. In turn Russell deposited these items in the collections of the California Academy of Natural Sciences at San Francisco at its meeting on March 30, 1857.

The body of Juana Maria was buried in the Nidever family plot in the cemetery of Santa Barbara Mission on October 19. On page 113, entry No. 1183 in the Libro de Difuntos (Book of the Dead), kept among the records at the Mission, is this paragraph:

1183
Juana
Maria
india
adta

En 19 de Ocro. de 1853 di sepulta ecca en este
cemento. al cadaver de Juana Maria india traída
de las isla de S. Nicolas, y como no habia
qn. la intendiese su idioma fue bautisada sub
condicione p^r el P. Sanchez y p^a qe conste le firme
Fr. Je. Ma. de Js. Gonsaz.
rubrica

(Translation)

1183
Juana Maria
Indian adult

On the 19th of October, 1853 I gave ecclesiastical
burial in this cemetery to the mortal remains of
Juana Maria, an Indian woman brought from the
Island of San Nicolas, and since there was no one
who understood her language she was baptized
conditionally by Fr. Sanchez and that this may stand
as true. I sign it.

Father Jose Maria de Jesus Gonzalez.

Father Zephyrin Engelhardt, in 1923 the aging Franciscan historian at Mission Santa Barbara, although intrigued by the story of Juana Maria, said in his book *Santa Barbara Mission*, p.451, after a discussion of the rescue:

"Were it not that Mr. Nidever's fame for veracity appears above suspicion, we should declare the whole story a myth, for the reason that, after a close examination of the Baptismal Registers at the Mission and at the Parish Church of Santa Barbara, we failed to discover any entry recording the woman's Baptism in either the Mission or the Parish Church. Likewise there is no record noted of her burial in the Mission Cemetery."

In the next paragraph Fr. Engelhardt quotes from an article in the *Ventura Observer*, December 20, 1892, written by Dr. Stephen Bowers, who stated that in 1877 he had secured "a translation of their record of the event (*i.e.* the story of Juana Maria) by a competent Spanish scholar," from the archives of Santa Barbara Mission.

In spite of this Fr. Engelhardt stubbornly refused to admit that such a record existed, saying, "We found no such account among the numerous papers in the Mission Archives nor anywhere else."

One must excuse the Reverend Father for his doubts. He was ailing, and his eyesight

dim. He may well have seen the smudged entry of Juana Maria's burial and baptism in the *Libro de Difuntos* many times but had passed it over.

On the evening of January 19, 1944, two clerics of Mission Santa Barbara, Frater Blaise Cronin and Frater Kenneth Henriques, who, having obtained permission from their superior to search for the record of Juana Maria in the archives, as part of the research they were doing for an article "Juana Maria," to appear in the publication "Priestly Studies," Vol. XII, No. 2, Winter 1944, found the entry quoted in a foregoing paragraph within about fifteen minutes. No longer was there any doubt about the legendary lost woman of San Nicolas.

All that is mortal of the last surviving inhabitant of the dying island of San Nicolas today rests in the hallowed ground of the Campo Santo of Mission Santa Barbara. *The Daily Independent*, Santa Barbara, November 8, 1883 remarked that Juana Maria, "whose heroism and exile are celebrated the world over, but whose grave remains unmarked and unhonored in the Nidever lot in the cemetery," is likewise wrong, because now it is known that she was a real person and a plaque to her honor has been placed in the cemetery, although the exact location of her grave is not known. Perhaps a study of the Nidever lot might reveal its presence.

One more note and then we shall let Juana Maria rest in peace.

The rescuers stated she had two shag-skin dresses among her effects. One is reported to have been given to Fr. Sanchez at the Mission. Her water bottle (of which there is a contemporary wood cut in *Hutchings California Magazine*, illustrating an article "Narrative of a Woman Who Was Eighteen Years Alone on the Island of San Nicolas, California," by C. J. W. Russell, November 1856) was presumably lost in the fire in San Francisco in 1906.

What happened to the other shag-skin garment?

My belief is that it too, unless by some miracle saved from the same fate as the water bottle, went up in the holocaust of April 1906.

The Daily Alta California, Sunday November 13, 1853, carried a relatively commonplace item about a Ladies' Fair which was to be held in the Musical Hall on Bush Street, San Francisco on the evening of Tuesday the 15th of November. A raffle was to be held and "a great variety of curiosities will be on exhibition, some of which, from their rarity and peculiarity, will be well worth the attention of the scientific and the curious. Some of the most singular objects will be disposed of by lot or raffle or as may at the time be thought proper and advisable. One of the most singular things on exhibition will be the dress of an old Indian woman who for seventeen years lived:

Alone, alone, all, all alone
Alone in the wide, wide sea—
And ne'er a soul took pity on,
Her soul in agony."